THE BURGESS PERSIAN LETTERS

Edited by BENJAMIN SCHWARTZ

PART II

[HENRY BURGESS TO CHARLES BURGESS] *Hempstead, October 18, 1830*

Mr. Hanson gave me yesterday a deplorable account of the condition of the East whither you and my dear Edward are bending your steps. He says that the Plague is raging at Trebizonde and other places: — that the Cholera morbus has not yet spent its ravages: — that trade is very bad in Persia, and that the Persians will buy nothing at Constantinople. But, he anticipated, that in a few months the diseases would disappear and trade revive. Not that the trade was affected by the diseases alone — there being a great glut of goods generally. But he said that nobody hardly is now shipping, instead of every-body, and that he had himself just now been buying Manchester goods, to send out, because he obtained them at a reduction of five per cent; which is a plain proof that he calculated on a speedy revival of business at Constantinople.

I have paid the insurance on your goods amounting to £53.17.6. Messrs. Hanson will write out to Mr. C. Hanson tomorrow to advance, if necessary, 200£, I having engaged by a letter written to them, according to their desire, to honour any bill drawn by you in that gentleman's favour not exceeding that am^{t}. In drawing any bill, if you have a necessity for drawing one, you must be careful to draw it at three months after *sight;* — four months would be better than three.

* * *

I wrote to you from LPool in my way out to Ebro. The part of that letter written on the Rail-way[9] is a great curiosity. Any distinguished Englishman would consider it such. You cannot imagine what interest another specimen which I wrote at the same time has excited.

[CHARLES BURGESS TO HENRY BURGESS] *Constantinople, December 9, 1830*

I wrote you a hasty line by the courier, which went off immediately after our arrival. I hope you would get it safe, as from the length of our passage no doubt you would be somewhat anxious. We start on the 11th on board an Austrian ship for Trebizonde, having decided upon that route for various reasons, which I will now state. 1st. It is much the cheapest and the quickest. 2nd there was no

[9] The Liverpool and Manchester Railway was formally opened to the public on Sept. 15, 1830, just about one month before the date of this letter. While the Stockton and Darlington Railway, completed in 1825, had demonstrated the practicability of the steam locomotive on its tracks, the Liverpool and Manchester was the first railroad designed and built for the use of steam locomotion. Ebro, of course, stands for Edinburgh.

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caravan going to Erzeroum from here just now and we should have had considerable difficulty in getting the mules required. 3rd Mr. Brandt[10] there is very anxious to form a connexion with Persia and my friends here were desirous that I should see him and if possible come to some agreement to that effect. He will most probably go with us to Erzeroum, where he already has an agent, if the trade is ever carried on regularly that must be the point of disembarkation and I was particularly anxious to try that route. 4th. The Plague is over there and I have no fear on that score in fact if you look at the circumstances there is scarcely any reasonable ground for anxiety with regard to these diseases. In the last twenty years in both Turkey and Persia there is no instance of an Englishman having died of either plague or Cholera, two have come to my knowledge to have taken it but both have recovered.[11] If Edward were not with me, I assure you I should go without the slightest hesitation into the most infected places.

C. Hanson has been particularly kind, when you see his brother do not fail to express our sense of his goodness — his charges on the goods have been 1 per cent and he has got us off more than half the Turkish duties therefore by paying him this we are considerably gainers. The flannel we shall be too late for Persia therefore I only take a small quantity on. The remainder is gone to the Sultan and I believe sold at a good profit, but the answer is to come today. Our long passage was a most serious misfortune, as it has thrown us so late in the winter but this promises to be a mild one and I have no doubt of getting on. On my return I have every reason to expect I shall bring silk and C. H^{n}. promises that on my writing to him that I am on my way, he will remit to England £1500 or £2000 — this may be a great accommodation should we be at all late which I trust will not be the case. I think there is a great deal to be done in the Persian silk particularly as it so facilitates the getting off my goods immediately and a quick return. I have drawn upon you for £200 at 61 days after sight which was what he wished and as the date is Decr. 10th it will come due about the time you expected. I could not with prudence make the date longer as this was his desire. I hope you will not be inconvenienced by this. Business here is just now very flat, but from all I can learn of the Persian trade I think better than I ever did of my assortment.

The news from Persia is not good. The plague is in Tabreez but have little doubt but that it will be over by the time we get there. I do not think it im-

10 English consul at Trebizond, cf. letter of Edward Burgess, postscript to the letter of Charles, dated Jan. 17, 1831.

11 This seems quite incredible, in view of the frequent European quarantines and "cordons" in times of plague, cf. especially Charles's letter from Corfu, dated July 23, 1835, referring to a Neapolitan quarantine of continental travellers, due to the outbreak of cholera in Toulon and Nice, and the article in *Revue de l'Orient*, série 1, tome 1, p. 69–87, *Des quarantines; nécessité de les réformer par suite de leur adoption en Angleterre et en Autriche*, by L. Aubert-Roche.

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probable that I shall go on to Teheran where I have a friend Manoocher Khan[12] the second minister of state who would immediately give me any quantity of silk and take my goods. Pray send me the best information you can as to the prices of silk, wool, opium, yellow berries, and gums generally if you could send me out the list prices current it would be of great use. I have taken silk samples from hence and hope to do good in this article.

Syeed Khan is still here. We are the best friends possible, he has many plans and great talent for carrying them into execution and as Charles Hanson says, I have but little doubt that in the end some of them will hit, it is decidedly our policy to be well with him. He has at last succeeded in procuring from the Porte his recognition as Persian political and mercantile agent at Constantinople and he leaves this in two days by way of Genoa for England, and I do not think it impossible but that he may succeed there, you will of course be very civil, do him any services in your powers and above all send me as full information as possible as to what he does. We have entered into a sort of agreement with regard to the silk I may bring, he gives me letters to his friends in Persia who are the possessors of quantities and in any amount of silk I may procure through his mediation, above the value of my own goods in Persia, we are to be equal sharers, that is to say he has a half share in the profit or loss of that which is procured on credit, having nothing to do with my goods or that part of the silk or other property I may procure in exchange but merely in the overplus which he gives his name to as joint security — but this I am at liberty either to use or not as I see fit — on arrival, I cannot see any possible danger in this but probable advantage therefore do not consider you will blame me in having thus far connected myself with him, besides I wish to stand well with him for the chances of the future, and you will of course act upon this principle. I know no man more likely to work himself up again. I now come to the question of our shipment from this to Trebizonde.

I enclose you the bills of lading and C. Hanson has written to his house in London full particulars of the ship, who can be referred to if you wish to insure, a part to cover English engagements, the company here would have done it, but as their capital is limited and they have already taken a considerable amount on board this vessel they could not do more, but as my goods are all in cases, *coppered,* and not subject to an average, they ought to do it in London at from two to two and a half per cent. C. Hanson is shipping goods by her of which he only insures a small part of, there is seldom any instance of a vessel being lost going to Trebizonde the passage is a very short one, the ship good, and the Captain has traded here for twenty years, and we are with the property in case of getting

[12] Manuchehr Khan, governor of Ghilan, later governor of Ispahan, and commander of the expedition against the Bactrian chief, Mohammed Taki Khan.

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on shore in fact the advice of the most experienced people here was to insure nothing, but having stated these particulars, and leaving my own opinion out of the question I must leave it to you. We start on Sunday, the day after tomorrow and you may suppose we are much hurried, in this has been the case with us ever since our arrival, you will hear again very shortly from Trebizonde, I hope.

Edward is in perfect health and I hope happy. We both go this evening to dine with Sir R. Gordon[13] who has been particularly kind to me and desired that E. should be introduced to him. He acquits himself very well in society.

[CHARLES BURGESS TO HENRY BURGESS] *Erzeroum, January 17, 1831*

At length I have the happiness to address you from this place, having arrived yesterday night, after a journey by sea from Constantinople to Trebizonde, and by caravan in 13 days from thence. The Black Sea treated us very civilly, our passage was eleven days during which we were more frightened than hurt, although from the state of ship and Captain we have every reason to be thankful the goods are perfectly safe, and I believe not at all damaged either by sea or land. We were unfortunate in not seeing Mr. Brant at Trebizonde, he was gone to Erzeroum and after waiting three days to see him I was obliged to depart. I met him on the road during a snow storm on a mountain side, he was very civil but of course we could have very little communication. I shall write him from this.

I have great hopes of forming a connexion which may be advantageous. Mr. J. Hunter[14] to whom Mr. Cartwright[15] gave me the letter of introduction, I hear, is a very pleasant man, if he should fall in your way mention the reason which prevented my delivering the letter which was my connexion with poor Hart. As this reason is now alas no longer in force I should be very ready to enter into any arrangement which might be deemed expedient by him or Mr. Brant, mention also that I hope to be in England next autumn and shall certainly see him.

The news from Persia is good, plague and Cholera both over and every body returned to Tabreez and no further deaths. I am told on all sides that my goods will meet a very ready sale and think it most probable that I shall bring back silk if I can make it clear itself as it so much facilitates the getting off of my goods. Many people who have seen part of the samples of my assortment are much astonished at the good choice. They say there never was such a lot taken into Persia. If no revolution or popular commotion occurs I have every hope of doing

[13] Sir Robert Gordon, special British commissioner from the London conference (of England, France, and Russia) on Greek affairs, accredited to the Porte.

[14] Mr. J. Hunter, from the reference to Major Hart, would seem to have been a schoolmaster.

[15] Presumably Thomas Cartwright, secretary to the British embassy at The Hague.

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well but do not let us anticipate, in two months more I will send you some more decided news. Write me every information you possibly can with regard to silk every body says it must rise and is the safest possible article for speculation, but I depend much upon your advice on this point.

We are both in excellent health and spirits. E. stands travelling remarkably well and is getting on with Turkish — he will fill up this as I am exceedingly busy.

[*Postscript by* EDWARD BURGESS*]

However we arrived in safety at Trebisond and found that the plague was over except in two houses but that it had been very bad and had carried off upward of 3000 people. In the Caravanserai where our goods were, we were told that four hundred men had died within the last three months. At Trebisond we were very kindly received by M. Fontanie the French Consul, Mr. Brant the English Consul being gone to Erzeroum; and we remained in his house whilst at Trebisond. From Trebisond here our road has lain entirely among mountains until within twenty miles of Erzeroum when we came onto the plain (entirely covered with snow and surrounded on every side by snow mountains) at the end of which stands the town. Here we proceeded to the house of Mr. Zorab, a Levantine, who is employed by the British Consul at Trebisond and stationed here. I am now writing in a room of his house.

The house belonged to one of the unfortunate Armenians who went away with the Russians when they gave this place back to the Turks. These poor people, all of whom were living in comfort and many of them in affluence here, were some of them persuaded by the Russians' promises, and at last when they (the Russians) found that many would stay they *drove them out of the town with whips and forced them* to follow the army, since that time they have been living in tents and have been subject to the greatest privations. Some have returned but these are very few as the Russians will not allow them to do so if they can prevent it. Fifty thousand people have thus most cruelly been forced to leave house and home. The consequence is that this place is almost ruined and instead of being the capital of Asia Minor as it ought from its situation to be, and as it has in great measure formerly, it is a desolate place the houses in ruins and the remaining part of the people as poor as rats.

* The rest of Edward's letters will follow those of Charles, in chronological order.

Erzerum was captured by the Russian general Paskievicz in 1829 and restored to Turkey after the Treaty of Adrianople. The shake-up in pashas referred to here by Edward was due to the invasion of Syria by the Egyptian pasha, Mehemet Ali. Edward was right; the new pasha never raised the ambitious levy he had announced, and consequently played no very important role in the struggle with Mehemet Ali.

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There has just arrived here a fresh Pasha (the old one is to be removed to Diabekir) his name is Azget Pasha. I happened to be in the street when he was entering the town and as all the people were bowing down almost to the ground I thought I must give him some sort of salute being remarkable from being the only Frank present and from my standing upright, so I touched my cap as he passed to which he bowed very civilly. This Pasha is a strick disciplinarian and a great promoter of the new system of Turkish tactics; it is said that he is going to raise ten thousand regular troops here but this is of course exaggerated.

We arrived here on the 6th; when this letter will go I know not but of course by the first tartar going to Constantinople. I shall keep it open until we start for Tabriz. — The Thermometer this morning (the 19th) at 7 o'clock stood at –0– and it has never been above 6 degrees above it any morning since we came here. Looking from Erz Roum over the plain you see nothing but snow, not a tree, not a bush, to relieve the eye. You here and there see about three small villages but these have no trees about them and are only distinguished from the plain by the mud walls of the houses showing black, amid the waste of snow. What a contrast from Constantinople and Trebisond, the latter in particular is surrounded with mountains the tops covered with snow and the sides clothed with roderdendrums, arbutus myrtle and other shrubs mostly evergreen.

At Trebisond we had two days shooting in company with a Mr. Abbot a young man who came there with Mr. Brant: I am no shot (at least at birds flying, a bullet at a still mark I shoot well) and cannot boast of ever having struck a bird flying except ducks and these are in such numbers all along this coast and are always in flocks that a man might almost shoot them blindfold.

(21st) I have left Mr. Zorab and Charles in another room and am now (about 8 P. M.) squatting on my carpet with C's desk on my knees finishing this letter. Close to my hand are my pistols (this is a regular practice; travellers in Turkey when on the road never sit down without their pistols close at hand) and sitting on the floor near me is an Armenian servant casting up his accounts. Behind me leaned against the wall are my double barrelled gun and Turkish sword and my cartridge box lies on the carpet close to them. All around lie cloaks, coats, trunks, blankets Turkish slippers and other travellers traps. At one end of the room is a wood fire on each side of which Charles' and my carpets are and firewood but, at the other end of the room is the door, some cupboards and a sort of gallery over the cupboards. The windows are three in number one foot long by four inches in width of one pane of glass, quite at the top of the room. You now have a description of our room which is much like all the better sort of rooms that I have seen here except that glass is a great rarity and only to be found in the best description of houses; oiled paper is substitution in all the inferior ones.

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We start again tomorrow, we and all our baggage traps etc have arrived here safe except poor Gipsey who was stolen from us at Constantinople and we since learnt that the Sultan had her among his greyhounds. This is not the first dog belonging to Englishmen that has been stolen either directly or indirectly for the Sultan. Cupps the other greyhound is in good health but is of a very delicate constitution and does not like travelling thro' the snow at all.

What I have said about the Russians you may *rely upon as a fact* and I think a more disgraceful fact never was recorded of any people. Wherever we have been mentioning that we are Englishmen puts us instantly on a friendly footing with the Turks; no man living in England can conceive the great name the English have all over the East — may we continue to deserve it — although of late years our political conduct towards the Turkish government has done a great deal towards lowering us in the eyes of that power.

[E. HAMMOND[16] TO CHARLES BURGESS] *Pera, February 14, 1832*

Sir Stratford Canning[17] desires me to inform you that the Messenger Crotch will deliver to you two bags of despatches, one for London, the other for Vienna, and he hopes that you will proceed on your journey with all convenient expedition:

His Excellency desires me to add that, in consequence of the quarantine said to be established between Bavaria and Austria, it will be advisable for you to concert with Mr. Forbes at Vienna as to the route you should pursue. Should there really be a cordon on the Bavarian frontier, it may perhaps be advisable to proceed through Bohemia, Saxony and Prussia (in which, being all infected countries, you are not likely to meet with any such impediment) and embark at Hamburgh for London.

[G. S. LEE TO CHARLES BURGESS] *Foreign Office [London], April 4, 1832*

I have laid before Viscount Palmerston[18] your letter of the 29th Ult°., enclosing a Memorandum of the Expences incurred by you, on your late Journey with Despatches from Constantinople; and I am directed by his Lordship to acquaint you, that the Chief Clerk of this Department has been authorized to pay to you £207, which is the amount usually allowed to Kings' Messengers for their Expences in performing a similar Journey.

16 Edmund Hammond, secretary at the Constantinople embassy, later permanent under-secretary at the Foreign Office.

17 Sir Stratford-Canning, famous British ambassador to Turkey.

18 England's great foreign minister.

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[M[IRZA] BABA TO CHARLES BURGESS[19]] *Tuesday, November 26, 1833*

His Excellency the ameer Nazim[20] heard that you left this today for Ardibel. He desired Jahangar Khan Shahgie to send some people to accompany you as far as Ardibel and bring letters both from you and Fate Ali Khan, that you are safely arrived there, so send letters stating your safe arrival. Get from Fate Ali Khan at Ardibel to give you horsemen to escort you to Tallish and so on, and at every opportunity let us hear from you both your health and safety.

[CHARLES BURGESS TO HENRY BURGESS] *Risht, Province of Ghilan, February 1, 1834*

I write you these few lines to inform you, that, yesterday, the last parcel of the silk I have purchased here was despatched for Tabreez, and that tomorrow morning "Inshallah" I follow. We are now in the depth of winter, and I have the tremendous chain of mountains called Elbūrz to get through, therefore it is possible I may meet with some delays on the road, but they cannot be of much importance as this year very little snow has fallen comparatively. This letter I despatch by a "Kansed" or foot messenger, who I am despatching to Edward in Tabreez, and who will of course arrive many days before I can, having ninety mule loads of silk to look after.

The actual quantity I have purchased will be in English lbs. about 26,000. I might have gone much more largely into the speculation, but as prices here are comparatively high, I feared a fall, and thought it not prudent to invest too large an amount in one article. I have made some other purchases of Caviar, Gum, and some of the manufactured silk of this country for trial in England, but the amount is not considerable. If the last quotation from Constple holds good, silk will yield a profit of 20% at the prices I have purchased here, and as all the crops even from China of last Autumn must be come to market, I cannot but consider the speculation as holding out a fair and reasonable prospect of advantage. Edward will have made some purchases in Tabreez, the proceeds of which will, I trust, have reached you long ere this, of the exact amount of E's transactions I am unacquainted.

It gives me great pleasure to inform you, that, the death of the poor Prince Royal[21] has not in the slightest degree affected the internal tranquillity of Persia, nor is there any ground for fearing confusion until after the death of the Present

[19] Mirza Baba and other names in this letter are presumably those of local chieftains. The only importance of this letter is the indication that Charles has returned to the East.

[20] *Amr i nizam*, "chief of the army."

[21] Abbas Mirza, died in 1833.

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King,[22] and even then the best informed people conceive that Adzerbigian generally, and particularly the town of Tabreez, will be safe and tranquil. I am now quoting, verbatim, the opinion of the Maurtinut Dowlut, the second minister of state, and the first in actual influence, Governor of the province of Ghilan.[23] During my stay here he has treated me with the most marked friendship and kindness, I cannot but feel happy at having acquired interest with such a man in this country. My friend McNeill[24] was kind enough to introduce me to him in the first instance.

I trust my Dear Father that you will keep up your health and spirits until it pleases God to allow us once more to meet. I shall delay as little as possible in Tabreez, or any where else, but you know the length of the journey I have to perform and the season of the year, make it impossible for me to fix an exact time for my arrival in England. My health is completely re[stored and] violent exercise, and the sea breezes have made me as strong if not stronger than I ever was in my life.

[GORE OUSELEY[25] TO CHARLES BURGESS] *49 Upper Grosvenor Street,* [*London*]
June 28, 1835

I beg to trouble you with a letter for Mirza Abul Hassan Khan[26] and another for Mirza Abul Kasim Kaim Mokám.[27] Should you not have an opportunity of delivering either of them yourself I will thank you to keep them until my friend Ellis[28] goes out and give them to him for delivery.

In reply to Sadik Dr. Seyd Khan's offer of a horse, I enclose two lines to him, merely referring him to you for the description of horse I should like, and which if you can get it I shall feel truly obliged to you to have forwarded to me here in the most speedy and economical manner. I should prefer an Arab mare; but as I know there are serious difficulties in the way of procuring one, if a mare cannot be procured, I must be content with a horse — he must be an Arab — and

22 Charles was an excellent prophet here; the death of Fath Ali Shah unchained fierce rivalries among his many sons for the accession to the throne.

23 Manuchehr (Manoocher) Khan, mentioned above.

24 Consul at Tabriz, succeeded Henry Ellis as minister to Persia in 1836.

25 Sir Gore Ouseley was the British minister who negotiated the "Definitive Treaty" with Persia in 1814.

26 Probably the Husayn Khan whose unsuccessful mission to England in 1839 (to request the recall of McNeill) caused him to "eat many sticks" on his return, i.e., he was punished by the bastinado.

27 The *Kaim Makam,* Mohammed Shah's deputy governor at Tabriz. For a brief account of his fate, cf. Sykes, *History of Persia,* v. 2, p. 328.

28 Henry Ellis, Minister Plenipotentiary to Persia until 1836.

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very handsome, small head, short ears, flat forehead, large nostrils, shoulder well back, strong for an Arab, although not large, short back, and tail well set on.

As to colour I must not be too fastidious. The only colours I particularly object to, are a dun and a light chestnut or sorrel. Those I like best are black, brown muzzle, very dark chestnut or dark bay — but of course I would not object to Bays of any kind or Greys — Age under six.

Pray believe me greatly indebted to you for the readings with which you have had the kindness to assist me, and call upon me without ceremony whenever and wherever I can be of use to you.

[CHARLES BURGESS TO HENRY BURGESS] *Corfu,*[29] *July 23, 1835*

We arrived here all well to day, after a very pleasant but fatiguing journey during the whole of which we had travelled night and day. The only unfortunate part of it was our not being able to get through the Neapolitan territories, owing to the absurd quarantine regulations of that government.[30] We had purposed going the most direct route to Corfu, on Rome, Naples, and across to Otranto on the opposite coast, there to embark for Corfu. When we arrived at Rome we found that the Neapolitans had made a new law that no persons coming from France either by Land or sea should enter their territories until they had been sixteen days in Italy, the cause of this was the Cholera having broken out with violence at Toulon and Nice. Of course we could not submit to this delay. We therefore went back to Ancona still in the Papal dominions and there embarked on board the Ionian steamer, which we were very lucky in catching. Had this "contreteins" not occurred we should have reached Corfu three days sooner, however we have much cause to be thankful that the Ancona route was open to us, for the sixteen days detention would have been bad indeed. On 25th, Captain Stewart, Johnstone[31] and myself leave for Zanta, thence to Patras, Corinth and Athens and then up the Archipelago to the Dardanelles. According to our calculations we hope to reach Constple in seven days, but it may be a day or two more than that, at all events we are all three inclined to use every possible dispatch. I do not think the Emma[32] will be gone as at this season ships usually make very long passages, in fact I would rather bett that I shall be at Constple before her than otherwise.

29 Charles is now on his way back to Persia after almost a year spent in England.

30 The inference here is that Charles has travelled overland, since his passage through plague-infested areas has made him subject to quarantine.

31 The British Army List for 1835 records a W. S. Stuart and Charles Cornwallis Johnstone as cadets of the Hon. East India Company's service, with temporary rank of Ensign while undergoing special training at Chatham. These may be the two accompanying Charles on the trip out to the East.

32 For a further account of the ship, *Emma,* see Charles's next letter.

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With regard to Edward I hope you have no doubt I cannot help thinking that had we had a little more confidential intercourse in Lo[ndon] unalloyed by temper we should have perfectly understood each other, and at the same time I much blame myself for in any shape giving way to irritable feeling which never lasted longer than the discussion which gave rise to it.

[CHARLES BURGESS TO HENRY BURGESS] *Constantinople, August 10, 1835*

We arrived here all well on the 7th inst. and found the Schah already returned having discharged her cargo at Trebizond and the Emma half way up the Bosporus, so that as to time I have managed exactly to hit the mark. My goods per Schah are now on their way to Erzeroum and I go on with those of the Emma which will form the last detachment. The Persian trade is here dull owing to the want of respectability and credit of the Persian merchants, prices in Persia still up and goods of all descriptions are much wanted. Edwards letters are very encouraging on all these points. In politics also a move has taken place very favourable to me; the late Prime minister has been completely disgraced and it is said put to death,[33] and in the course of these changes my most intimate friend to whom I have formerly rendered signal services has become commander in chief of the whole army.[34] Who is Prime minister is not yet decided[35] but it is thought that a person very favourable to English interests will succeed, at all events these changes are very favourable for the Old minister had become a complete Russian and was deservedly hated on all sides. Edwards letters are very cheerful, and he has been going on very well in every respect. I have heard much about him from Kirwan and Moore the two Irish gentlemen of whom you have heard and who have been living some time with Edward. They are very fond of him and are both very gentlemanly nice fellows. You may probably see them in England but certainly not for many months. The Emma has made a pretty good passage out here but poor Twigg[36] has suffered a good deal from the ill tempered brutal conduct of the Captain who has treated him ill in all respects. His character for bad temper is very well known out here and I am much surprized that Hodgson and Powis should have recommended a Captain who was so well known to be the worst tempered man in command of a ship to the Levant. He got the vessel on shore at the Dardanelles, and after having done so behaved excessively carelessly and stupidly about the goods he was obliged to discharge so that even now we are not sure that he has not lost some part of his

[33] The Kaim, Makam, cf. note 27.
[34] Manuchehr Khan.
[35] It was Haji Mirza Aghasi.
[36] Twigg was Henry Burgess's clerk and bookkeeper.

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cargo. However I think he knows his profession and we may get rid of him entirely in a few days. If it is in any way possible I will not fail to avenge Twiggs insults but do not take any notice of what has passed until the whole cargo is out of his hands. Mr. Ellis's letter has been of the greatest service in the arrangement of the duty questions. Lord Ponsonby[37] has exerted himself much and sees the matter quite in the same light I do, he has also been very confidential with me on Eastern politics of which he takes a very just view. Although we have not succeeded in altogether escaping the duties we have got off so much of them that the amount to be paid will be very trifling.

I this day send home to Messrs Spooner Atwoods two bills drawn at 61 days sight dated 30th July for £1000 each. I send them to Messrs Atwoods as you may probably be out of town when the letter arrives and as our joint note of hand will probably be about coming due. When these get to hand I am very anxious the bills should be accepted as soon as possible. I send you on the other sheet a copy of the letter I write to Mr Atwood on the subject, which I hope you will approve of. You can get the bills from the bank, discount them in the most favourable manner you can and take back our note of hand which you will be kind enough to destroy. When you next write will you be kind enough to send out a complete and formal account current, which may serve as a document for us in any case, of the justice and absolute necessity of this I am sure you will be convinced, and also on a slip of paper separate an extract from the Bill book with all outstanding engagements.

I now come to a subject on which it is exceedingly difficult for me to write and which I premise by assuring you that in any thing I may do or say I am actuated only by sincere feeling for the general welfare of the family, and the more I think on that subject the more strongly the conclusion is forced upon me that we ought to be as distinct as possible and that in saving Edward and myself you are doing that which is most likely to in future conduce to the well being of the family. I consider it of the last importance that you should endeavour by all means in your power to liquidate our account, and keep our general credit good. I cannot help looking forward to a prosperous result to this adventure, and if it pleases God to grant this I think you cannot doubt that Edward and myself would in every respect participate with the whole family. Regarding making arrangements with Hansons for any *present* advances it is totally out of my power to do so as I am already tresspassing most largely on Charles Hansons kindness and confidence. The whole responsibility of my advances is thrown upon him and he very kindly allows me to take all my goods forward to Persia without re[que]sting anything to cover the very large amount advanced. This

[37] British ambassador at Constantinople.

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being the state of the case can I ask of him a present further advance? I hope very very soon to get home some funds to meet pressing engagements but for the present the matter must rest where it is. Tell George I have been dreadfully hurried with all kinds of business as not to have been able to find a moment to write him but next weeks post will bring a full letter from me.

I am writing in a room full of Persians and do not know what I am saying. In the meantime God bless you all.

[CHARLES BURGESS? *no date.*]

(A single sheet which was removed from a bound volume by Mrs. Thomas F. Burgess in December, 1938, it being the only page in the volume that was not blank. The paper bears the J. Whatman watermark of 1834. The handwriting is that of Charles H. Burgess.[38])

yet been able to induce his people to consent to his plan of giving the rivers with Chereekund to the Russian powers. Poolut Khan of Cera Papā an independent Turkuman chief who possesses Salt mines and has considerable power is decidedly opposed to Khayat Khan's ideas. His country is about 10 fursangs from Chereekund. Fortunately the Turkumans stood firm to Meer Ibrahim Khan's interest in the rivers and the Colonel and Mirza Alexander returned without effecting anything. The Russians have been driven this Summer from the Fort of Mangurklak by the Kozakas or Tartars after a seige of 22 days; it was defended by 200 men and six pieces of cannon; of the former 60 succeeded in making their escape in boats.

About 2 months since a Russian cutter of war was taken near Astrachan by the Turkuman boats. She mounted 4 guns and had 45 men on board; the commander has been ransomed at a high rate, the men are either killed or sold

[38] This appears to be a memorandum of the type which went into the "letters" to Mr. Villiers, Lord Ponsonby, and the Duke of Richmond, cf. Appendices. Briefly, the political situation referred to derives from the humiliating treaty of Adrianople (1829) forced upon Mahmud II by the victorious Russians. As a consequence of Turkish concessions, Russia conceived it her privilege to take over the entire Caucasus. A long period of guerilla warfare with the wild tribes ensued, frequently to the discredit of Russian arms, cf. especially the nearly contemporaneous record of events in the *Revue de l'Orient,* 1844, série 1, tome 1, p. 257–291, *Études sur la Circassie,* by Alphonse Denis, and série 1, tome 4 p. 150–166, 261–287, *Situation des Russes dans le Caucase,* by Ignace Xavier Hommaire de Hell. Military outposts and even forts, like the one described in this note were repeatedly cut off and stormed, and even Russian shipping was at times attacked. The names Poolut Khan and Khayat Khan are presumably those of local chiefs. Mir Ibrahim Khan seems to have been a Russophile Persian. Mirza Alexander, or rather, Mirza Mohammed Ali Kazem Beg was a Persian who had been converted to Protestantism by an Anglican mission. He spent most of his life in Russian service, became a noted Oriental scholar and has to his credit many works on the languages, literatures, etc., of the Near East. Count Simonich was the Russian envoy to the court of Persia. Mir Abu Talib would seem to have been the Persian ambassador (?) or special commissioner to St. Petersburg.

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into Slavery. Lately an Armenian vessel coming from Astrachan was attacked; she had about 20 people on board who were armed. They defended themselves and beat off the Turkuman boats with the loss of 2 killed and three wounded.

The total number of Russian vessels of war is seventy-five Brigs each carrying 6 guns on 2 Cutters with 4 guns each. There are 40 Merchant Brigs 12 of these belong to Meer Ibrahim Khan — 8 to other Persians and the remainder to Russians and Armenians.

Mirza Alexander sounded all the rivers of Mazanderand and Ghilan till he came to the Sifeedrood when he proposed doing so there but Meer Ibrahim Khan firmly and successfully opposed it and wrote to Auglar Khan, then Govr. warning him of what had been going on, this note was enclosed to Count Simonitch and formed one of the subjects of complaint of the Russian Govt. to Meer Abou Talib.

[CHARLES BURGESS TO MESSRS. C. S. HANSON AND CO., *Constantinople*]

London, March, 1839

In order to reply to the queries put by your house here to me, I must refer to the events of the last seven months, which have had so unfortunate an influence over all my undertakings. Premising that I can only do so imperfectly being still confined to my room, and in too weak a state to write at much length.

You are aware that when the goods you now hold were sent to you, nothing was anticipated, but that the political relations between Eng^d^. and Persia would have gone on in their usual course. Most unhappily the result has been totally different. When the news of the first breech between the Schah and Mr. McNeill arrived a total stop was put to my proceedings. When we got intelligence of every thing being settled, I again set to work and got delivered in London, circa £6000 value of cotton manufactures. The last parcel of these had not reached London when the news of the last rupture with Persia came, and nearly at the same time I again fell ill, probably from exposure in the winter, and for now nearly two months I have been in bed or on the sofa. The goods all remain at the carriers warehouses, but I think you will perceive that as matters now stand it is impossible for me to come to any decision about them *immediately*. You know that all my transactions are so mixed up together that during a suspension of intercourse between the two countries it is out of the question for me to make any movement. Those best informed here expect all to be very shortly settled; sh'd this be the case the goods I now have would immediately come out to you, and I should proceed with my other transactions. This however is certain, that until I see my way more clearly than at present, I cannot make

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a decision, but there is little, if any, doubt of this state of things being speedily at an end. My state of health of course adds much to the difficulty, but this I am assured by the M. D will soon be better, and as the weather is now mild, I hope I shall be able to get about before many days. If you give all I have stated — I fear very imperfectly — consideration, I think you will accede to my request of holding the goods a short time longer, until you can hear again from London. I am aware that this is an indulgence, but I think it is warranted by late events.

* * *

The foregoing letter is the last we have from Charles in reference to his Persian affairs. A number of letters written by him between the years 1840–1852 reveal that he spent his time wandering from one European watering-place to another in an attempt to regain his health. At one time he became interested in an iron-works project in partnership with his father, and at various times, when health permitted, he tried his hand at a number of ventures, all of them apparently brought to an end by illness. The following, the last letter we have addressed to him, has been included in this edition for its timeless quality.

* * *

[S. Villiard to Charles Burgess] *Aix la Chapelle, May 5, 1850*

Il y a un an, à pareille époque, nous faisions ensemble de magnifiques projets, qui devaient recevoir une prochaine exécution, vous devez vous en souvenir. Mais les circonstances sont venues à la traverse, et moi qui comptais sur votre appui, je n'ai pas eu, depuis, de vos nouvelles. Depuis cette époque j'ai traîné une vie misérable, — espérant toujours dans un sort meilleur, et ne le trouvant jamais —— c'est ce qui fait que je n'ai pu vous rembourser la somme dont vous avez eu la bonté de répondre pour moi. Peut être un jour porrais-je le faire? Je le ferais même très certainment si vous voulez bien me donner votre appui en ce moment, en me fournissant les moyens d'éxpérimenter le projet dont je vais vous entretenir.

Pendant les derniers temps du séjour que j'y ai fait, il est venu à Spa un Mr. de Bruxelles, qui a joué une progression de 19 coups, en allant de 1 pièce à 39, pour trouver le coup de 2. Quand il l'avait trouvé sur une couleur, il passait sur l'autre. Il a joué ainsi une semaine entière sans sauter, et à l'unité de 3 f. seulement il a emporté 15,000 f. — J'ai noté ce système, je l'ai étudié depuis en y apportant des modifications qui le rendent encore plus certain, et j'ai trouvé q'on pouvait obtenir des résultats considérables. — Ainsi, en jouant seulement 20 coups par jour et en augmentant l'unité depuis *10 gros* [*chen*] jusqu'à 40 florins, ce qui

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serait le maximum à Hombourg, on pourrait, en 3 mois, gagner 400,000 francs. En supposant de nombreux revers, il serait toujours possible de gagner dans la saison 150,000 f.[39] — Pour jouer ce jeu il faut 153 pièces, c'est à dire à Aix 51 thalers. — J'avais proposé cette combinaison à M. Oslanski qui m'avait promis la somme; je suis venu à Aix comptant sur lui; mais il se trouve en ce moment dans l'impossibilitié de le faire. Il me donne bien des espérances lointaines, mais je ne puis les attendre dans la position où je suis. — J'ai donc pensé à vous, Monsieur, et si vous vouliez bien me confier cette somme, je suis convaincu que j'obtiendrais, pour vous et pour moi de beaux résultats. Vous me rendriez un grand service et c'est à ce titre surtout que je vous la demande. — Je n'insiste pas du reste; il y a là une double question: celle de la possibilité dont vous seul êtes juge; puis une question de confiance que vous apprécierez. — Je vous prie de me donner votre reponse d'ici au 19, si toutefois cette lettre vous parvient

[39] Mr. G. William Bergquist is the author of the following note:

The "system" mentioned in this letter is what is known as a progression or "martingale." These systems are not concerned with the particular numbers or places on which one should place's one's bets, but rather with the procedure as to the amount of the bets, according to whether the bets are won or lost.

Most gamblers maintain that the past does not affect the future and the chances of winning a bet may not be affected by a previous loss, but if the following bet is won, the previous loss is wiped out. Progressions in betting are based on this theory and it is considered advisable to increase one's bet after a loss, in order that one's wins will balance or exceed the losses. The fallacy in this theory lies in the assumption that one can not always lose.

The simplest progression is the system of doubling the stake after each loss. The stakes in the event of a succession of losses would be: 1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32. Each win would give a net profit of one unit. It would seem that the system mentioned in the letter was either this one or the so-called Montante Stanislas. Such systems are usually used in conjunction with betting on the "simple chances" in Roulette, namely: odd or even, black or red, first 18 numbers or last 18 numbers. All these chances pay even money. That is to say you win an amount equal to the amount of your stake.

The systems used vary in their details as to the amount the bet is increased after each loss and the number of times a certain amount is wagered. They are all supposedly based on rough laws of mathematical probabilities, but all scientific investigators have insisted that they are based on fallacies and, if adhered to, will result eventually in ruin. What some of the more conservative ones often do is to prolong the play at the table with a minimum of loss.

Insufficient details are given in the letter as to how the bets are to be made in the system mentioned. Obviously, the writer was not going to disclose his secret in its entirety. It is difficult to translate accurately since words are used with very special meanings, intelligible only to a gambler. It is clear that he proposes to play the black or red, for he says, when he hits upon it on one color, he changes to the other. This probably means when he wins on red he switches to black. This is in accordance with the gambler's dictum, "A change to black is imminent."

Briefly, as near as I can make out, the writer's system consists of making his first stake three francs (the unit) or any multiple of that. If he wins, he will continue to play the same stake until he loses. After his first loss, he adds two units to his stake. If he loses again, he adds two more units and continues to do so until he wins. When he wins, he continues to play the same stake he won with until he loses again. His next stake will be increased by two units. This continues until he has increased his stakes in this manner 19 times which would bring it to 39. No one but the writer knows what the modifications are. No doubt the absolute certainty(?) of winning depends upon these modifications.

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assez tôt pour cela. — Si vous vouliez n'exposer que 25 th. je crois que j'obtiendrais le reste de M. Oslanski, alors nous partagerions par tiers.

Maintenant autre chose. — comme je vous l'ai dit je me trouve dans une position très pénible. Si vous ne pouvez pas m'aider dans le sens qui précède, je me permettrai de m'adresser à vous comme à un protecteur. Je suis véritablement malheureux et j'ose réclamer votre bienveillance et votre appui; ne me les refusez pas je vous en conjure. — Par suite de revers de fortune je n'en ai plus des ressources, il faut que je tâche de m'en créer. Si vous pouviez m'aider pour cela, je vous en serais profondément reconnaissant. — Je voudrais quitter l'Europe et m'en aller au loin refaire une position quelconque. On m'a dit qu'il y avait à Londres une compagnée de colonisation pour l'Australie, qui donnait le passage gratuit sur ses vaissaux, et qui faisait même quelques avances à ceux qui voulaient y aller. Par votre protection, ne pourrais-je profiter de ces avantages? Tel est le service que je reclamerais de votre bonté. — Je sais un peu l'Anglais; pendant la traversée je finirais par le parler. — Je m'engagerais à tout ce que l'on voudrait. Je possède quelques connaissances que je pourrais utiliser là bas. Enfin je ferais tout ce qu'il est possible pour réussir.

Voilà, Monsieur, ce que j'ai voulu vous demander. Ayez la bonté de me repondre un mot là dessus. Vous n'aurez pas obligé un ingrat je vous le promets. Je voudrais avoir votre reponse le plus tôt possible, car je ne sais véritablement que devenir. Je vous prie de m'adresser votre lettre sous le nom de

Jules David, Hôtel de Hollandes, à Aix la Chapelle.

Encore une fois je fais appel à votre bonté; dites-moi ce qu'il y aurait à faire pour en arriver là et je le ferai. Mais tâchez avant de me donner les moyens de réaliser l'espèrance première.

Adieu, Monsieur, je vous prie de croire à toute ma reconnaissance je vous offre l'assurance de mon respectueux dévouements.

(To be continued)

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